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THE AKALIS ARE AT THEIR LOWEST EBB EVER. RADICAL SIKHS ATTACKED SGPC CHIEF DHAMI AS HE TRIED TO JOIN A MORCHA FOR THE RELEASE OF 'BANDI SINGHS' ON JAN. 18

Gurdwara Management Committee (HSGMC)—pursuant to the apex court ratifying, in September, the constitutional validity of a 2014 legislation passed by the then Congress regime. Panthic Sikhs see it as a move to divide Sikhs further. As it is, the SGPC has control only in Punjab, Himachal, J&K and Chandigarh now. The pain was reflected in Akal Takht jathedar Giani Harpreet Singh's Facebook post where he said the apex court verdict was akin to a second "geographical murder of SGPC" (the 1947 loss of turf being the first). A line that followed was more inflammatory: "I wish! Sikh sentiments should be respected even for an independent political system." The pointed allusion was not lost on anyone.

In a conversation with INDIA TODAY, Khattar said separate management of gurdwaras was not going to affect the unity of the faith. But the swiftness with which his regime moved has sparked a war with SGPC president Dhami and the Akal Takht jathedar. Dhami told INDIA TODAY that the BJP-RSS is interfering in Sikh religious affairs and the HSGMC was part of this. Even those among the Sikh clergy who back Khattar's move criticise the appointment of Mahant Karamjit Singh, chief of the Yamunanagar-based Sewapanthi sect, as the chief of the new body. Panthic leaders do not consider the Sewapanthi as part of the fold, nor do they accept a mahant as the chief of a gurdwara management body. Daduwal, who's a former president of HSGMC, tells INDIA TODAY, "No Sikh can accept anyone other than the Guru Granth Sahib as the patron of any Sikh body." The issue has handed panthic leaders and radicals a surcharged issue to play with—freeing gurdwaras from "government control". Even moderate Sikhs are seeking an All India Sikh Gurdwara Act to have a reunited SGPC.

THE KHALISTAN SPECTRE

Panthic leaders, however, walk the razor's edge as their demands are often misunderstood to be in aid of the Khalistan cause. "Extremism appears romantic, but isn't," says Chanan Singh, a rehabilitated extremist. "We have gone through the struggle and know that no parents want their sons killed."

Which is why Amritpal's antics have put him in confrontation with other panthic groups. Things flared up on December 9 when Amritpal's supporters broke furniture at a gurdwara in Kapurthala's Biharipur village. Days later, they repeated the act at a gurdwara in Jalandhar's Model Town. Amritpal justified the vandalism, saying seating arrangements at the same level as the Guru Granth Sahib were sacrilegious. But all signs are that these incidents have lessened his pull.

For, a lot of water has flowed down the Sutlej since the cordite-choked '80s-90s. The demand for a separate homeland resonates only among a section of the Jat Sikhs, and it's tied up with their self-image of social dominance. Khalistan has no appeal among the Hindu population or to the vast OBC and Dalit segment across religions. The former makes up 32 per cent of Punjab's population. And cumulatively, the lesser endowed castes total about 65 per cent. OBC and Dalit Sikhs derive their spiritual sustenance and protective cover from the *deras* and other outfits that have sprung up in the past four decades. It's these that panthic outfits are waging war on—be it Amritpal against the Christian pastors working among Dalit Sikhs, or Dera Sacha Sauda's continuous confrontation with canonical Sikhism.

That's why Subhash Chander Singh, chief of the Radha Soami Dera Teja Singh at Amritsar, says: "There are no takers for Khalistan, some people are just using it for their own benefit. The real issues Punjab and Sikhism face are drugs, pollution of soil, air and water, and livelihood." Former Punjab DGP Shashi Kant too sees the radical element as outsiders. "These fringe elements keep making noise in the US, UK and Canada," he says.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, meanwhile, has kept up his outreach to the Sikhs. On December 26, he marked the first Veer Bal Diwas to commemorate the sacrifice of Guru Gobind Singh's sons. Then, Darshan Dhaliwal, a US-based businessman deported in 2020-21 when he came to organise a langar during the farm agitation, was conferred the Pravasi Bharatiya Samman. For the state and the Centre, there are strategic considerations to consider, with pro-Khalistan militants seemingly lurking in the shadows. Somehow, events have kept that pot simmering: take the recent mystery deaths of terrorists Harvinder Singh Sandhu, alias Rinda, and Harpreet Singh, alias Happy Sanghera, in Pakistan and Italy respectively, and the arrest of Kulwinderjit Singh, alias Khanpuria, from Delhi airport in November. There are those like Sikh intellectual G.B.S. Sidhu who believe this churn can throw up something good for the future. It's the present the government has to safeguard. ■